

La Sagrada Familia

In his unfinished basilica of La Sagrada Familia (begun 1882), Gaudí replaced Gothic buttresses with slanted columns and added soaring pinnacles, expressive sculpture and dramatic façades. The spires, steeples and entrance portals, built on a massive scale, evince both Gothic and Spanish baroque styling. One of the few conventions he adhered to was the Latin cross format, but little else complies with tradition. Three façades illustrate scenes from the Bible – the Nativity, the Passion and the Glory, with sculptures of holy figures modelled from ordinary citizens of Barcelona – while towers represent the Evangelists and the Apostles. Multicoloured mosaics and ‘pompom’ finishes on some pinnacles symbolize the mitre, ring and staff of Catholic bishops. Although he followed a mathematical structure for the building, Gaudí drew few plans, working more with models and his own impromptu ideas. During his lifetime, Gaudí completed only 4 of the 18 towers he had planned. Nonetheless, La Sagrada Familia presents a unique, unified and astonishing interpretation of art nouveau.

